

Word family: **plain / plainer / plainest / plainly / plainness**

Base word: plain

Comparative: plainer

Superlative: plainest

Part of speech: mainly **adjective**, also **noun** and **adverb** in fixed uses

Related forms:

* **plain** (adj.) — 樸素的；簡單的；清楚的；普通的；不加修飾的

* **plainly** (adv.) — 清楚地；坦白地；明顯地

* **plainness** (n.) — 樸素；簡單；平凡

* **plain** (n.) — 平原

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **plain shirt**

* **plain clothes**

* **plain design**

* **plain food**

* **plain language**

* **plain English**

* **plain fact**

* **plain truth**

* **plain to see**

* **plain-looking**

* **plain flour**

* **plain chocolate**

* **plain yoghurt**

* **plain text**

* **plain clothes officer**

* **plainly obvious**

* **speak plainly**

* **a plain**

Meaning in this passage

> He usually wore a **plain shirt**, dark trousers, and a pair of glasses.

Here, **plain** means:

simple in appearance, without decoration or a strong pattern — 樸素的；簡單的；沒有花紋或裝飾的

The shirt is not flashy, patterned, or highly decorated.

****中文翻譯：****

他通常穿着一件****簡單樸素的恤衫****、深色長褲和一副眼鏡。

So here:

****plain shirt = 款式簡單、沒有明顯圖案或裝飾的恤衫****

1. ****plain clothes / shirt (樸素的；沒有圖案的) — 樸素的；簡單的；素色的****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He usually wore a ****plain shirt****.

他通常穿一件****樸素的恤衫****。

Practice 2

> She chose a ****plain black dress****.

她選了一條****簡單素色的黑裙****。

Practice 3

> I prefer ****plain clothes**** without large logos.

我比較喜歡沒有大標誌的****簡潔衣服****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plain = 外觀簡單、沒有明顯圖案、裝飾或華麗細節的****

2. ****plain design / style — 簡約的設計 / 款式****

Practice 1

> The room has a ****plain design****.

這個房間的設計很****簡約****。

Practice 2

> He prefers **plain styles** to decorative ones.

相比有很多裝飾的款式，他更喜歡**簡單款式**。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain design/style = 沒有太多裝飾、圖案或複雜細節的設計

3. **plain food** — 清淡簡單的食物

Here, **plain** means simple and not strongly seasoned or elaborate.

Practice 1

> I ate some **plain rice**.

我吃了一些**白飯 / 沒有配料的飯**。

Practice 2

> He prefers **plain food** when he feels unwell.

他不舒服時比較喜歡吃**清淡簡單的食物**。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain food = 沒有太多調味、配料或複雜烹調的簡單食物

4. **plain yoghurt / plain cake / plain biscuit** — 原味的；沒有額外口味的

Practice 1

> She bought **plain yoghurt**.

她買了**原味乳酪**。

Practice 2

> I prefer **plain biscuits** to chocolate ones.

相比朱古力餅乾，我比較喜歡**原味餅乾**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plain food product = 沒有加入額外味道、餡料或裝飾的原味食品****

5. ****plain language — 清楚直接的語言****

A major abstract sense.

Practice 1

> The instructions are written in ****plain language****.

指示用****清楚易懂的語言****寫成。

Practice 2

> Explain the rule in ****plain language****.

請用****簡單直接的說法****解釋這條規則。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plain language = 簡單直接、容易理解、不使用不必要複雜詞語的語言****

6. ****plain English — 簡明英文；易懂英文****

Practice 1

> Can you explain it in ****plain English****?

你可以用****簡單易明的英文****解釋嗎？

Practice 2

> The guide translates legal terms into ****plain English****.

這本指南把法律術語改寫成****淺白英文****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plain English = 清楚、直接、容易理解的英文表達****

7. **plain fact / truth** — 明白無誤的事實 / 真相

Here, **plain** means obvious, clear, and undeniable.

Practice 1

> The **plain fact** is that we don't have enough time.

明擺着的事實就是我們沒有足夠時間。

Practice 2

> She told him the **plain truth**.

她把**赤裸裸的真相 / 實話**告訴了他。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain fact/truth = 非常清楚、直接，沒有修飾或隱瞞的事實 / 真相

8. **plain to see** — 顯而易見

Practice 1

> It was **plain to see** that he was tired.

很**明顯**看得出他很累。

Practice 2

> Her disappointment was **plain to see**.

她的失望是**顯而易見的**。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain to see = 很容易看出、非常明顯

9. **plainly obvious / plainly visible** — 顯然的；清楚可見的

Practice 1

> The mistake was **plainly obvious**.

那個錯誤**非常明顯**。

Practice 2

> The damage was **plainly visible**.

損壞情況**清楚可見**。

MCQ-ready definition:

plainly = 以非常清楚、明顯的方式

10. **speak plainly — 坦白直接地說**

Practice 1

> Let me **speak plainly**.

讓我**坦白直說**。

Practice 2

> She **spoke plainly** about the risks.

她**直截了當地**談到那些風險。

MCQ-ready definition:

speak plainly = 不拐彎抹角、不含糊地直接表達

11. **plain person / plain-looking — 相貌普通的；不起眼的**

This is an established but potentially sensitive appearance sense.

Practice 1

> He was rather **plain-looking**.

他的外貌相當**普通、不起眼**。

Practice 2

> She described herself as **plain** rather than beautiful.

她形容自己外貌**普通**，而不是漂亮。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plain = 外貌不特別漂亮、華麗或引人注目的****

12. ****plain room / building — 樸實無華的房間 / 建築****

Practice 1

> The room was small and ****plain****.

房間很小，而且****樸實無華****。

Practice 2

> The building has a ****plain exterior****.

這座建築的外觀很****簡單樸素****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plain = 外觀沒有太多裝飾、設計簡單而不華麗****

13. ****plain clothes (便衣) — 便服；非制服****

This appears in a special compound sense.

Practice 1

> The officer was wearing ****plain clothes****.

那名警員穿着****便服****。

Practice 2

> A ****plain-clothes officer**** followed the suspect.

一名****便衣警員****跟蹤疑犯。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plain clothes = 不穿制服、穿普通日常衣服的狀態，尤其指警員****

This is different from simply “simple-looking clothes.”

14. **plain text** — 純文字；無格式文字

A common computing sense.

Practice 1

> Save the file as **plain text**.

把檔案儲存成**純文字格式**。

Practice 2

> The message was sent in **plain text** rather than HTML.

訊息以**純文字**而不是 HTML 格式傳送。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain text = 不包含複雜格式、圖像或特殊排版的純文字內容

15. **plain flour** — 普通麵粉；中筋 / 無泡打粉麵粉

A standard BrE food term.

Practice 1

> Add 200 grams of **plain flour**.

加入 200 克**普通麵粉**。

Practice 2

> Use **plain flour**, not self-raising flour.

要用**普通麵粉**，不要用自發粉。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain flour = 沒有加入膨脹劑的普通麵粉

16. **plain chocolate** — 黑朱古力 / 無奶朱古力

Especially BrE, though terminology varies.

Practice 1

> The recipe uses **plain chocolate**.

這個食譜使用**黑朱古力**。

Practice 2

> She prefers **plain chocolate** to milk chocolate.

相比牛奶朱古力，她比較喜歡**黑朱古力**。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain chocolate = 一般指不含牛奶或奶成分較少的深色朱古力

17. **a plain (平原) — 平原**

A genuinely distinct noun sense.

Practice 1

> The village lies on a wide **plain**.

這條村位於一片廣闊的**平原**上。

Practice 2

> Herds of animals crossed the **plain**.

一群群動物越過**平原**。

MCQ-ready definition:

plain = 大片平坦或起伏很小的陸地

18. **plains — 平原地區**

Practice 1

> The animals migrate across the **plains**.

那些動物會穿越**平原地區**遷徙。

Practice 2

> Farming is common on the fertile **plains**.

肥沃的**平原**上很常見農業活動。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plains = 大片廣闊而平坦的陸地區域****

19. **plainly (顯然地) — 明顯地**

Practice 1

> He was **plainly nervous**.

他**顯然很緊張**。

Practice 2

> She was **plainly disappointed** by the result.

她**明顯對結果感到失望**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plainly = 很明顯、容易看出地****

20. **plainly (坦白直接地) — 坦白地；直截了當地**

Practice 1

> She told him **plainly** that she disagreed.

她**直截了當地**告訴他，她不同意。

Practice 2

> To put it **plainly**, the plan failed.

****簡單直接地說****，這個計劃失敗了。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plainly = 不作修飾、不含糊、直接地表達****

21. ****plainness — 樸素；簡單；平凡****

Practice 1

> I like the ****plainness**** of the design.

我喜歡這個設計的****樸素簡潔****。

Practice 2

> The room's ****plainness**** made it feel calm.

房間的****簡約樸素****令它感覺很平靜。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****plainness = 沒有太多裝飾、複雜或華麗元素的特質****

Important distinction 1: ****plain vs simple****

Very close, but not identical.

****plain****

often means:

- * not decorated
- * not patterned
- * not elaborate

****simple****

means:

- * not complicated
- * easy in structure or design

> a ****plain shirt****

素色 / 沒有圖案的恤衫

> a **simple machine**

結構簡單的機器

Something can be plain but technically complicated.

Important distinction 2: **plain vs ordinary**

plain

focuses on lack of decoration, striking qualities, or complexity.

ordinary

means normal, not special or unusual.

> plain clothes

樸素衣服

> an ordinary day

普通的一天

A plain object can still be unusual.

Important distinction 3: **plain vs basic**

basic

means fundamental or with only essential features.

plain

means not decorated or elaborated.

> a basic phone

基本功能電話

> a plain phone case

沒有圖案的手機殼

Important distinction 4: **plain vs boring**

plain

is usually neutral.

boring

is negative and means not interesting.

A plain room may be elegant and calming rather than boring.

Important distinction 5: **plain vs dull**

plain

simple and undecorated.

dull

can mean boring, not bright, or lacking energy.

> a plain shirt

簡單恤衫

> a dull colour

暗沉的顏色

Important distinction 6: **plain vs patterned**

This is especially relevant to clothes.

plain

no obvious pattern.

****patterned****

has visible designs, stripes, flowers, checks, etc.

> a plain blue shirt

純藍色恤衫

> a patterned shirt

有圖案的恤衫

Important distinction 7: ****plain vs solid-coloured****

These overlap.

****plain****

can mean no decoration/pattern.

****solid-coloured****

specifically means one uniform colour.

A plain shirt is often solid-coloured, but ****plain**** can also refer more broadly to overall simplicity.

Important distinction 8: ****plain language vs simple language****

Very close.

****plain language****

emphasizes clarity and directness.

****simple language****

emphasizes low complexity.

Good plain language is usually simple, but it also avoids ambiguity and unnecessary jargon.

Important distinction 9: **plain truth vs simple truth**

plain truth

the direct, unvarnished truth.

simple truth

a truth that is uncomplicated.

So:

> the plain truth

= 坦白的真相 / 赤裸裸的事實

not necessarily:

> an easy truth

Important distinction 10: **plain to see vs easy to see**

Very close.

plain to see

often slightly more emphatic or literary:

= obvious.

easy to see

neutral:

= not difficult to notice.

Important distinction 11: **plain person vs plain personality**

Be careful:

> a **plain-looking person**

= 外表普通的人

But:

> a plain personality

is less natural and could suggest an unremarkable personality.

So the appearance sense is strongest with:

* plain-looking

* plain face

* plain features

Important distinction 12: **plain clothes** vs **plainclothes**

plain clothes

ordinary non-uniform clothing.

plainclothes (usually attributive)

used especially with police:

> a **plainclothes officer**

便衣警員

This is lexicalized and should not simply be read as “an officer wearing simple clothes.”

Important distinction 13: **plain food** vs **bland food**

plain food

simple, lightly seasoned, uncomplicated.

bland food

lacking strong flavour.

Plain food can still taste good; **bland** often sounds negative.

Important distinction 14: **plain yoghurt vs plain food**

plain yoghurt

= original/unflavoured yoghurt.

plain food

= simple, not rich or heavily seasoned.

The Chinese translation changes, but both share the core idea of **no added extras**.

Important distinction 15: **plain text vs ordinary text**

plain text

is a technical computing term.

It means text without rich formatting or embedded elements.

ordinary text

just means normal text.

Not the same.

Important distinction 16: **plain vs clear**

plain

can mean obvious/direct.

clear

means easy to understand, see, or perceive.

> It was plain that he was upset.

很明顯他不開心。

> The instructions were clear.

指示很清楚。

They overlap in some abstract contexts, but not in physical-decoration senses.

Important distinction 17: **plainly** = obviously vs **plainly** = directly

Two important adverb senses:

plainly obvious

= 明顯地

speak plainly

= 坦白直接地

Context decides whether **plainly** concerns **visibility/obviousness** or **direct expression**.

Important distinction 18: **plain** vs **plane**

Classic spelling trap.

plain

- * simple
- * obvious
- * flat land

plane

- * aircraft
- * flat surface
- * geometric plane

They are pronounced the same but are different words.

Family-extension note

****Plain**** is a particularly rich polysemy word because it has several major modern branches:

1. ****simple / undecorated****

- * plain shirt
- * plain design

2. ****unflavoured / uncomplicated****

- * plain yoghurt
- * plain food

3. ****clear / direct****

- * plain language
- * plain truth
- * plainly

4. ****ordinary-looking****

- * plain-looking person

5. ****technical compounds****

- * plain text
- * plain flour
- * plain clothes

6. ****geography****

- * a plain / the plains

The first four senses share a broad conceptual thread of:

****without extra decoration, complexity, or concealment****

But ****plain = 平原**** is a genuinely distinct noun sense and should be kept separate.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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plain shirt	樸素 / 素色恤衫	undecorated	
plain clothes	樸素衣服	simple appearance	

plain design	簡約設計	little decoration	
plain food	清淡簡單食物	uncomplicated	
plain yoghurt	原味乳酪	no added flavour	
plain language	淺白語言	clear/direct	
plain English	淺白英文	easy-to-understand English	
plain fact	明白無誤的事實	obvious/direct	
plain truth	赤裸裸的真相	unvarnished truth	
plain to see	顯而易見	obvious	
plain-looking	相貌普通的	visually unremarkable	
plain clothes officer	便衣警員	non-uniform police	
plain text	純文字	no rich formatting	
plain flour	普通麵粉	no raising agent	
plain chocolate	黑朱古力	BrE food term	
a plain	平原	flat land	
plains	平原地區	broad flat land	
plainly obvious	明顯地	clearly apparent	
speak plainly	坦白直說	directly	
plainness	樸素；簡單	lack of decoration	

For your original sentence

> He usually wore a **plain shirt**, dark trousers, and a pair of glasses.

Here:

plain = 款式簡單、沒有明顯圖案或裝飾的

The speaker is describing Mr Chan's restrained, tidy style.

So **plain shirt** does **not** mean:

- * ugly shirt
- * cheap shirt
- * boring shirt

It simply means something like:

a simple, undecorated, probably solid-coloured shirt

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他通常穿着一件**簡單樸素的恤衫**、深色長褲和一副眼鏡。

For this passage, **「簡單樸素的」** captures the tone best.